▼ GLASSHOUSE



THE NEW FACE OF EMPATHY

The Jantar Mantar protests have given the Samajwadi Party a new political mascot: Dimple Yadav, wife of party chief Akhilesh Yadav. Videos showing the Mainpuri MP kneeling beside an injured protester, tending to another unconscious student, confronting police and so on, had gone viral in Uttar Pradesh. Analysts say it has recast the soft-spoken Yadav *bahu* as a "compassionate yet assertive leader". Party insiders say the moment was planned. Ahead of the Parliament session, the SP leadership chose Dimple, not Akhilesh, to lead the '*paidal* (walking) march' from Parliament to the protest site. With unemployment, paper leaks and recruitment irregularities likely to dominate the 2027 UP election, the party is planning youth outreach programmes across the state. Dimple now could be at the centre of its campaign to win young voters.

Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

▼ COST OF VICTORY

SO, WHO'S PAYING?

Perhaps late in the day, but **Siddaramaiah**, who recently joined the league of former CMs, has realised how much electoral politics has changed. "Earlier, the people of the constituency would pool money to help us win," the veteran Karnataka Congressman reminisced at an event near Mysuru on July 25. Today, he rued, the equation has reversed, with candidates expected to pay the voters. The veteran leader, who will be 82 when Karnataka votes again in 2028, also reiterated that he would not contest another assembly election. For a leader whose career has spanned some five decades of Karnataka politics, the announcement was both a personal sign-off and a bleak commentary on the rising cost—and changing character—of elections.

